

## DPA Plan

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| Ethics reference number: <b>ERGO/FEPS/111889</b>                                            | Version: 1 | Date: 2026-03-31 |
| Study Title: Discovering Hidden Community Leaders                                           |            |                  |
| Investigator(s): Lyndsey Ballantyne, Oscar Seip, Cassandra Gould Van Praag and Emma Karoune |            |                  |

The following is an exhaustive and complete list of all the data that will be collected through our landscape mapping exercise and qualitative interviews.

### General project documentation

- Project meeting notes.
- GitHub repository – general information about project and contact information of team.
- GitHub project board – work package details, milestones, deadlines.

### Work package 1 – Landscape mapping

- Data about individuals
  - o Participant ID
  - o [WP1 consent](#)
  - o First and last name
  - o Email address
  - o Professional (institutional) affiliations
  - o Role title
  - o Career stage
  - o Professional profile links (e.g. Institutional profile pages, GitHub, LinkedIn)
  - o Subject/domain area
  - o Community affiliations
  - o Community responsibilities
  - o Community engagement level (7 levels, as defined by Mozilla Mountain of Engagement)
  - o WP2 participant (y/n)
  - o WP2 consent
- Data about Institutions
  - o Institution name
  - o Institution webpage
  - o Key contact person (if known)
- Data about Communities
  - o Community name
  - o Geographic scope
  - o Mission
  - o Community maturity level
  - o Funding sources
  - o Website and other URL links

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- Data about Community activities

- title
  - start and end date
  - responsible people
- type of activity
  - scale of impact
- durability
- importance
- outputs
- URL links

## Work package 2 – Qualitative interviews

- Participant ID (from WP1)
- Interview recordings
- Interview transcripts
- Interviewer notes
- Data analysis/thematic analysis
- The data is relevant to the study purposes because our objective is to understand who does community-related work in our focused area (RSE/SSI community) as part of our landscape mapping (WP1). Therefore, we must collect data about the individuals, where they work, the communities they support and the type of activities they undertake in those communities. We also need to be able to contact these individuals to collect any further information that is not publicly available (with their consent) and contact them to invite to interviews (approx. 20 interviews, WP2). We will also collect data during interviews and then use this for thematic analysis to answer our research questions. The data are adequate at this stage because we are exploring this new area in this study. We are restricting our data collection to SSI Fellows to surface new information and to refine our interview questions for a larger study. The data are not excessive because we will only collect the data we need to answer our research questions.

Personal data will be collected and processed with the consent of participants. Data regarding Institutions or communities will be collected from public records.

WP1 data accuracy is ensured by allowing WP1 participants to submit their own information and being sent a copy for their own review. We will also manually review and clean data before analysis.

We will select a range of individuals from WP1 to invite to WP2 interview aiming for diversity in domain, sector, career stage, institutional affiliation, supported communities and community responsibilities (max n=20). This is an exploratory study to test our workflow and refine questions for a larger study. We anticipate that a maximum of twenty interviews will be sufficient to indicate saturation in our population sub-sample of the UK Research Technical Professionals ecosystem (i.e. SSI Fellows) and test our qualitative methodology. Interview transcripts will be automatically generated using MS Teams, and we will manually correct any errors to ensure accuracy.

Data will be stored on the Investigator's computers and University servers. The data will be held in accordance with university [policy on data retention](#).

- Landscape mapping – University server - SharePoint

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- Qualitative interviews – University server - SharePoint

Data files will be protected by password to access SharePoint and laptops/desktops will be protected by password protection.

The data will be destroyed by Lyndsey Ballantyne in with accordance with the University of Southampton's Research Data Management Policy.

The data will be processed in accordance with the rights of the participants because they will have the right to access, correct, and/or withdraw their data at any time and for any reason. Participants will be able to exercise their rights by contacting the investigators: (e-mails: [l.ballantyne@soton.ac.uk](mailto:l.ballantyne@soton.ac.uk), [oscar.seip@manchester.ac.uk](mailto:oscar.seip@manchester.ac.uk), [cassandra.gouldvanpraag@rcmcooperative.com](mailto:cassandra.gouldvanpraag@rcmcooperative.com), [emma.karoune@rcmcooperative.com](mailto:emma.karoune@rcmcooperative.com)).

Where consent is not given for identification, the data from qualitative interviews will be pseudonymised by Cassandra Gould Van Praag for analysis. Consent forms will be linked to the data by a reference number kept in a password protection folder in the University SharePoint drive. This data will not be openly shared at any point.

The landscape mapping exercise will only identify individuals through the use of publicly available data or data that has explicit consent for sharing.

The following data - landscape mapping data - will be transferred outside the European Economic Area (EEA) to use Kumu software. It will be subject to processing by Kumu - see <https://kumu.io> and [Security](#). All communication between our browser and kumu servers is encrypted over HTTPS. Kumu servers are hosted on Amazon's AWS infrastructure and each project's data is stored in a separate CouchDB database for additional privacy. All projects are backed up daily by Kumu and the backups are retained for a minimum of 30 days. They have a strict employee access and confidentiality policy that prevents Kumu employees from accessing projects without prior consent. Access to the internal kumu visualisation will be restricted to the project team through the creation of password protected kumu accounts.

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## ***Data Protection Act 2018 (DPA) best practice***

If the study involves personal or sensitive data, explicitly explain how data will be collected, stored, analysed, held securely, and in turn destroyed. The DPA does not apply to anonymous data and a DPA Plan is not required in the case of such data.

The principles of the DPA are that personal data must be:

1. Processed fairly and lawfully.
2. Processed for specified purposes and in an appropriate way.
3. Adequate, relevant and not excessive for the purposes.
4. Accurate and up-to-date.
5. Not kept for longer than necessary.
6. Processed in accordance with the rights of data subjects (participants).
7. Protected by appropriate security, both practical and organisational.
8. Not transferred outside the European Economic Area (EEA) without adequate data protection controls.

Data is recorded information, whether stored electronically on computer or in paper-based filing systems. Personal data is information about an identifiable living individual. It can be factual, such as the date of a person's interview, or an opinion, such someone's view on how the person has performed on a task. It obviously includes individuals' contact addresses or telephone numbers. (Less obviously, note that personal data is being processed where information is collected and analysed with the intention of distinguishing one individual from another and to take a particular action in respect of an individual. This can take place even if no obvious identifiers, such as names or addresses, are held.) Processing is any activity that involves data, including collecting, recording or retrieving, using, disclosing, organising, adapting, changing, updating, or destroying it.

The DPA identifies Sensitive Personal Data as:

- a) the racial or ethnic origin of the data subject (participant);
- b) his political opinions;
- c) his religious beliefs or other beliefs of a similar nature;
- d) whether he is a member of a trade union;
- e) his physical or mental health or condition;
- f) his sexual life;
- g) the commission or alleged commission by him of any offence or
- h) any proceedings for any offence committed or alleged to have been committed by him, the disposal of such proceedings and the sentence of court in such proceedings.

The processing of sensitive data must meet at least one of the 10 stricter conditions laid down in Schedule 3 of the DPA. It may be useful to know that condition 1 of this schedule permits processing of such data if the data subject has given his explicit consent, and condition 5 if the information has been made public as a result of steps deliberately taken by the data subject.

Keep in mind that the Police have a right of access to personal data held by the study for the purpose of safeguarding national security; preventing or detecting crime; prosecuting or apprehending offenders; assessing or collecting tax; or protecting the vital interests of the data subject or another.

Researchers are exempted: from the second data protection principle, meaning that personal data can be processed for purposes other than for which they were originally obtained; from the fifth data protection principle, meaning that personal data can be held indefinitely; and from the data subject's right of access to his personal data provided the data is processed for research purposes

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and the results do not identify data subjects. In addition, the Data Protection (Processing of Sensitive Personal Data) Order 2000 para.9 provides that processing in the course of maintaining archives for research purposes is permissible where the sensitive personal data are not used to take decisions about any person without their consent and no substantial damage or distress is caused to any person by the keeping of those data. These exemptions do NOT give a blanket exemption from all the Data Protection Principles to data provided and/or used for research purposes. Researchers wishing to use personal data should be aware that the Data Protection Principles still generally apply, notably the requirement to keep data secure<sup>1</sup>.

A study may seek to anonymise the data it keeps. Anonymisation involves the removal of participants' personal information (names; e-mail address; whatever data it is that might permit identification; etc) from the data such that what remains cannot be used to identify them. Note that audio and video recordings (and often transcriptions too) cannot easily be anonymised, so they should normally be treated as non-anonymous data. Anonymised data can usually be kept without security and can easily be passed to other investigators for specialist analysis.

The DPA requires access to be granted to participants to all of their data, if any part of that data allows their identification. If the data has been anonymised, two issues arise.

1. If the personal information has been removed from the data AND DESTROYED, then the DPA is no longer applicable, and the data can be kept without security. However, investigators should note that they will be unable to follow up or subsequently contact participants in any way, or associate individuals with particular data, and should not attempt to suggest they might do so.
2. If the personal information has been removed from the bulk of the data, but NOT destroyed (ie, is kept separately), then the DPA remains applicable. In this situation, the personal information needs to be (a) kept both separately and securely from the anonymised data, and (b) to be linked or 'keyed' to the anonymised data, such keys to be similarly kept securely (and often kept with the personal information).

If personal data is collected, in the 'Participant Information', inform the participant of:

- the processes the study will take to ensure data security;
- their right to access and correct their data and their right to request removal of their data;
- the authority which will give them access to their data (provide the contact information).

If sensitive data is collected, or the study involves clinical studies, human tissue samples, invasive procedures, or young or vulnerable people, provide additional detail. In the 'Participant Information', inform the participant of:

- the separation of identifying data and the anonymisation process;
- the method of linking the consent form (if any) to the participant's data;
- the processes for the destruction of all study data (if appropriate).

The study should conform to the University policy on data management applicable:

<http://www.southampton.ac.uk/library/research/researchdata/>

Investigators may find the University's survey platform useful:

<https://www.isurvey.soton.ac.uk/>

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<sup>1</sup> [http://www.jisc.ac.uk/publications/generalpublications/2001/pub\\_dpacop\\_0101.aspx](http://www.jisc.ac.uk/publications/generalpublications/2001/pub_dpacop_0101.aspx)

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## Contacts

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